

[Return to Search](#)

Words and the Dogon world

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For the most part, Dogon men avoid obscene jokes or references in front of their wives and children. But there are certain individuals who “do not know shame” and who tell jokes and obscenities when their families are present. At first, the children run away and the women are shocked, but in the end they realize that this aspect of his character must be taken as it is, and they will laugh with him, entering a joking relationship or mà[unavailable]u with him. ¹¹⁶

[115](#)
[Informants](#)

[522](#)
[Humor](#)

[593](#)
[Family Relationships](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

Their behavior touches on an essential aspect of Dogon mentality. Sexual jokes, which have the same cathartic value as ordinary jokes and jokes between mà[unavailable]u ¹¹⁷ are thought to be purifiers of the sexual organs, whereas the other forms of joking purify the body. Dogon tell sexual jokes to women with whom they have joking relationships (mà[unavailable]u), which includes his maternal uncle's wife, and the wives of friends and brothers, but they do not exchange them with their own wives. ¹¹⁸ Indeed, in contrast to wives, everything is permitted with mà[unavailable]u women except sexual relations. This is why joking with wives ceases with sexual subjects, whereas “making faces” with inaccessible women acts as purge to any guilty desire one might feel toward them. ¹¹⁹ And when a man is unable to forego telling such jokes in front of his family, the listeners put a different psychological complexion on his action by assuming the role of his joking partners.

[522](#)
[Humor](#)

[593](#)
[Family Relationships](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

On the other hand, the husband does not hesitate to tell his wife tales that illustrate conjugal life and what a woman must do in order to gain her husband's love. Here is a typical one:

522
Humor

539
Literary Texts

593
Family Relationships

A man had four wives. The first one would heat up his bath water and would give it to him. While he was bathing, the second one would take his pants and would go into the house to repair them. The third wife would come out and would put him on her back to carry him into the house. The fourth one would cook meat, put it on a spoon, and put it in his mouth. So he bit the back of the one who was carrying him into the house, the one who cared for his pants ran away, and the one who had given him meat went into the house. He declared that he wanted to be with the one who had the food.

116. Thus Amadigné's uncle, our great source for all kinds of tales and fables, was not uneasy about making "wry remarks" in front of his wife and grown daughters. They were used to them and would laugh, saying he "had no shame."

117. Later we will return to these exchanges between **joking** relatives in connection with the social value of jokes.

118. **Joking** about sex with one's wife is permitted, but it appears that it is avoided in practice.

119. More accurately this exchange serves as a symbolic replacement for the sex act. We should note that whatever obscenity these jokes contain is merely allusive and takes an enigmatic form.

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